

The Writing Career Map

Seven ways writers actually get paid, what each one pays, and the first three steps into each.

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Read this first

Most advice about "becoming a writer" skips the only question that matters: which kind. The seven paths below want different skills, different temperaments, and different amounts of patience. Picking wrong costs years.

I have done five of the seven. The figures are ranges I have either been paid or seen paid directly. They are not survey data and they are not promises.

1. Technical writing

You explain how something works to the person who has to use it. Software documentation, API references, user guides, internal process docs.

Pays: the most reliable money on this list. Salaried roles are common; contract rates sit well above general copywriting.

Suits you if: you like precision more than flourish, and you are happy asking an engineer the same question three times until the answer is clear.

First three steps

1. Pick one open-source tool you already use and read its documentation critically. Find the page that confused you.
 2. Rewrite that page properly. Submit it as a pull request.
 3. Do this twice more. You now have a portfolio and three references, which is more than most applicants have.
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2. Ghostwriting

You write, someone else's name goes on it. Books, LinkedIn posts, newsletters, thought-leadership articles for executives.

Pays: the widest range on this list. A LinkedIn retainer and a full ghostwritten business book are different businesses.

Suits you if: you can subordinate your own voice and you are genuinely fine with anonymity. Some writers find this unbearable. Find out before you sign.

First three steps

1. Write three posts in three clearly different voices. Not three topics, three voices. This is the actual skill.
 2. Pick one narrow niche you can speak credibly about. "I ghostwrite for founders of B2B SaaS companies" beats "I ghostwrite".
 3. Approach people already publishing inconsistently. Someone who posts brilliantly then vanishes for six weeks has the problem you solve.
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3. Content and SEO writing

Articles built to rank in search or to answer a buyer's question. The volume end of the market.

Pays: per word or per article, and the floor is low. The top of this market pays well and looks nothing like the bottom.

Suits you if: you can research fast and you are interested in *why* a page wins, not only in writing it.

First three steps

1. Learn how search intent works. This is a weekend, not a course.
2. Write three pieces in one industry. Depth in one beats breadth across five.
3. Pitch companies, not content mills. The mills set the rate; companies negotiate.

Honest warning: this is the path most exposed to AI. The commodity end is going. The end that survives is the writer who has done the thing, interviewed the people, and has an opinion.

4. Copywriting

Writing that gets someone to act. Sales pages, emails, ads, landing pages.

Pays: the highest ceiling here, because the output is measurable in revenue. Also the steepest learning curve.

Suits you if: you are genuinely curious about persuasion and you are comfortable being judged on a number.

First three steps

1. Hand-copy ten sales letters that worked. Longhand. This feels absurd and it works.
 2. Rewrite the landing page of a product you actually use and send it to them unsolicited.
 3. Take one small client on a results basis. One documented win is worth more than any certificate.
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5. Journalism and features

Reported writing for publications. Interviews, investigation, narrative.

Pays: poorly relative to the skill required, with real exceptions at the top.

Suits you if: the reporting is the part you love, not the writing. If interviewing strangers drains you, this is the wrong path.

First three steps

1. Find a story in your own town that nobody has written.
 2. Pitch it to one local outlet. Three paragraphs: the story, why now, why you.
 3. Repeat monthly for a year. The portfolio is the career.
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6. Books, fiction and non-fiction

Your name, your book.

Pays: almost nothing for most, life-changing for a few, and the distribution is brutally skewed. Treat the advance as the payment and anything after as a surprise.

Suits you if: you would write it regardless. That is not a motivational line, it is a filter. The economics only make sense if the writing is its own reason.

First three steps

1. Finish something short first. A finished 3,000-word essay teaches you more than an unfinished 80,000-word novel.
 2. Read twenty books in the category you want to publish in, recently published, and note what they have in common.
 3. Decide traditional or self-published before you write, not after. They want different books.
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7. Teaching what you know

Courses, workshops, cohorts, coaching. You write, but the writing sells and delivers something else.

Pays: no ceiling, no floor, entirely dependent on audience.

Suits you if: you are two steps ahead of someone and can remember being where they are.

First three steps

1. Find the question you get asked repeatedly.
 2. Answer it publicly and completely, for free, at length.
 3. When people ask for more, charge for the more. Not before.
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Choosing

Three questions, honestly answered:

Do you need the money to be predictable? Then technical writing, content, or a salaried role. Books and journalism are not that.

Do you need your name on it? Then not ghostwriting, and probably not content.

Do you want to be paid for words, or for outcomes? Words is per-piece, steady, and capped. Outcomes is copywriting and teaching, which is volatile and uncapped.

Most working writers combine two: one that pays the bills and one that is the point. That is not a compromise, it is the normal shape of the career.

A note on AI

I use AI daily and I publish what I build with it. Here is the honest read.

The writing that is disappearing is the writing nobody wanted to read in the first place: filler, restatement, the 1,500-word article answering a question that needed a paragraph.

The writing that is not disappearing has one of three things in it: something you did, someone you spoke to, or an opinion you will defend. If your work has none of those, the tool is a real threat. If it has any of them, the tool is leverage.

Pick a path where you can have at least one.

Next

I write about the work, including the parts that fail, at bryancollins.com.
